

be done, you just need that kind of mindset instead of lamenting, and then it's feasible.

**Q:** There's a perception that there's a lot of interference from New Delhi in large public sector corporations, particularly in areas like banking where the chairman or her senior colleagues get calls from ministers and sometimes loans are granted on that behest. In your time at SBI, did you encounter any such thing?

**A:** I cannot say that I've not experienced anything like it... However, such calls or requests need not put you under any compulsion to abide by them. There are ways in which you can ensure that you are not doing the wrong thing, because nobody can force you to do something which is not rational. So, you have got to get the rationale straight and examine whether it's a viable case or not... For instance, not loans, but in things like job postings, there would be a lot of pressure to post a person here or there, but in respect of the new entrants, we said very clearly that the policy is during the first two years of probation, absolutely no changes would be allowed. If you want to join, you join; if you don't, there will be others to take your place. And we stuck to it, even if it meant that a certain person did not join. So the fact is you need to lay down your policy and then stick to it. If there is any such request from above, you just say you have to rationalise any decision as it could well come under scrutiny tomorrow. So, to take any such decision that is being asked for, I have to have these prerequisites. If they are available, great. If they are not available, I'm sorry, we can't do it. So, I had to be a little diplomatic in how we did it. But it wasn't such an insurmountable thing either.

**Q:** Now permit me a personal question. I'm sure your husband [ex-IIT professor Pritimoy Bhattacharya] is very accomplished in his own field, but you know, to be the chairperson of the largest bank in the country, did it ever cause any friction in the household, you being the more successful partner?

**A:** Both of us decided to give each other our own space. So there are many, many social events that I have attended all alone. In fact, once I told my husband, you should put in an appearance otherwise people may think that you're a figment of my imagination, and I don't want that. So very grumpily he would agree to come along. But he hated the shop talk which normally happens in such banking events, and I could relate [to that] because, when I went to any of his academic gatherings, well, I couldn't relate to his shop talk either, because then I was relegated with the spouses, discussing everything other than stuff that really interested me. But both of us accepted the fact

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that we had our own space. Many times he didn't accompany me, and many times I didn't accompany him, but we sort of worked it out. I think we are good, especially women, at making compromises. Having said that, we did have mutual friends and we got on pretty well together. Some of my bank friends are his best friends today and some of his IIT friends are very good friends of mine.

**Q:** I also want to ask you about your board memberships, because you sit on the board of Reliance Industries. How important is it to be a scrupulous and vigilant independent director? Do you think a lot of independent directors in India fall way short of the gold standard?

**A:** At the end of the day, you have to realise one thing—that these directors meet the company once in a quarter, or if it's a big company like Reliance we meet twice a quarter; so in this much time, there is only so much that you can review. Given that is the case, one has to understand that even by looking at what is being presented to you, you are at a disadvantage because the management will only show you what they want to show you.

So I think the merit of a director lies in being able to ask the right questions and being satisfied that the questions are being answered in as complete a manner as possible. Developing that can take a little time, can actually take up quite a bit of your time, especially in the beginning as you get to know the company. There are companies that do three-day off-sites on their campuses and things like that. So I was on the board of one such company where we would start at seven in the morning and end at six in the evening for two and a half days. Even dinner would be with the company executives. Now, that gives you a much better insight into what is the working of the company and what they are doing. There are many more casual conversations from which you can pick up a lot of things but not every company is able to do that. **BT**